

Unsettled Times: The Contestation and Reproduction of Flexible Scheduling in Pandemic-Era Restaurant Work

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Abstract

Flexible capitalism fosters the organization of worker time around demand, with challenging consequences for precarious and low-wage workers. I examine how this paradigm of work time fared in a context of economic and social disruption, namely the COVID-19 pandemic. Drawing on a qualitative study of restaurant work in the U.S., I argue that shifts in power over work time interacted with the moral and relational nature of time, resulting in both contestation and continuity of the flexible time paradigm. This paper has implications for understanding factors shaping change and stability in flexibly organized and precarious work.

Keywords

flexible scheduling, precarious work, low-wage work, pandemic work, tight labor markets

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Flexibility has arisen as a widespread way of organizing work in the postindustrial economy (Kalleberg, 2013). Posing a break from the organization of time in industrial capitalism, flexible capitalism operates around logics of nimbleness and adaptation to changing conditions. For workers, this means their labor and time are organized around demand, rather than a standard schedule. Of course, while this mode of structuring work has become more common since the 1970s, it has long been the case in various types of work (Quinlan, 2012), including restaurant work (Cobble, 1992).

Work time in contexts governed by “flexibility” poses contradictions which highlight contrasts between worker- and employer-driven flexibility (Gerstel & Clawson, 2018). Scholars have found that workers may embrace flexibly organized work as an alternative to a “9 to 5” or to jobs organized around the time order of industrial capitalism (Occhiuto, 2017; Snyder, 2016). However, the companies that employ or contract workers according to a logic of “flexibility” can still make significant demands on workers’ time and even demand flexibility *from* workers (Clawson & Gerstel, 2014; Snyder, 2016). Indeed, the flexible organization of time is a mechanism of employer control over the labor process (Halpin, 2015; Wood, 2020). Thus, paradoxically, workers may end up struggling for control over time in flexible jobs. These dilemmas are especially consequential in low-wage and precarious work,¹ where schedule instability and a lack of workplace protections for workers can be particularly deleterious for individuals (Henly & Lambert, 2014; Jacobs & Padavic, 2015; Lambert et al., 2012; Lambert, Henly and Kim, 2019; León-Pérez et al., 2021; Schneider & Harknett, 2021).

This paper aims to clarify mechanisms through which this paradigm of work time is both contested and maintained by examining it in a context of economic as well as social disruption. After initial waves of widespread job loss, the pandemic labor market was characterized by marketplace bargaining power (Silver, 2006; Wright, 2000) for workers, given staffing shortages across many industries including low-wage industries. Pandemic lockdowns and job loss also introduced changes to the temporal patterns of individuals’ lives, including among low-wage and precarious workers; sometimes, these experiences lead to new temporal aspirations such as prioritizing family, turning down work, or investing work time in more passion-driven pursuits (Ravenelle & Kowalski, 2022). By examining the flexible time paradigm in a context of economic and social disruption, we may more clearly observe aspects of this paradigm that are taken for granted in periods of greater stability.

Drawing on qualitative methods including participant observation and interviews, this paper asks: how has the paradigm of flexibility been experienced in flexibly organized work since the pandemic? I apply this question to the case of restaurant work—both in front of the house (customer-facing) and

back of the house (non-customer facing) settings—where practices that promote employer-driven flexibility and schedule variability are widespread (Haley-Lock, 2012; Halpin, 2015; Henly & Lambert, 2014; Jacobs & Padavic, 2015; Wilson, 2020) and where social and economic effects of the pandemic affected workers and businesses across the U.S. I parse meaning-making around time through a framework drawn from existing literature as well as my data, which distinguishes between three different dimensions of time—as a site of power, as a moral entity, and as a relational entity. The “power” dimension refers to time as a site of struggle between employers and workers, while the idea of time as a moral entity refers to the relationship between time and feelings or beliefs about what constitutes “the good.” Finally, for my purposes, the relational nature of time refers to the interrelated nature of workplace actors’ schedules. While scholars of precarious work have often emphasized questions about the relationship between power and flexible scheduling, attention to the moral and relational dimensions of time may complicate views of precarious workers’ experiences with time.

I find that shifts in employee-versus-employer power over work time intersected with moral and relational meaning-making around time, resulting in both change and continuity to employer-driven flexibility. First, looking at the relationship between time and power, the moment of worker power caused by the tight pandemic labor market gave many workers greater control over their schedules. However, power over the schedule interacted with moral and relational views of the schedule, which could offer a basis for investment in or resistance to flexible scheduling. Some workers clung to moral and relational views of time that reinforced the paradigm of employer-driven flexibility, while others, bolstered by their favorable labor market position, articulated alternative interpretations of work time that were more aligned with employee control over time.

These findings contribute to the study of flexible work by illustrating that workers’ temporal meaning-making and scheduling practices are embedded in multiple, intersecting aspects of time. This paper also contributes to the study of reproduction and change in the organizational practices of flexible work, as it points to the multi-faceted nature of temporal meaning-making and action as an explanation for both stability and change in flexible scheduling.

Literature Review

How the Meaning of Time is Constructed and Contested

How are meanings of time constructed, contested, and upheld? Broadly, scholars have offered two complementary visions. In one, macro-level

societal institutions shape the experience and meaning of time. In the other, micro-level processes allow specific meanings of time and time-related practices to unfold. This paper seeks to build on these theories, especially concerning the role of micro-level processes in how time is experienced in organizations.

The macro-level perspective focuses on the role that institutions play in organizing time. Scholarship in this vein argues that the organizing institutions of a historical period shape the “time discipline” of that period, or the meaning and organization of time in that period (Glennie & Thrift, 1996; Thompson, 1967). Of these, work is just one institution that shapes people’s sense of time, but it is an important one. The state is another institution which shapes taken-for-granted aspects of social time like the calendar (Bourdieu, 2014). Other institutions like the church and the realm of trade have also shaped the “time sense” of individuals (Glennie & Thrift, 1996; Snyder, 2013, 2016). When societal institutions change, so do taken-for-granted “temporal landscapes” of that society (Tavory & Eliasoph, 2013). In turn, the flexible economy has shaped a new “time sense” that poses a historical break from the temporal organization of many kinds of work in the industrial economy (Snyder, 2016).

However, the macro-level perspective is insufficient for understanding how people experience time. Attention to micro-level processes fills in this gap. Structures of time rest on the consent of the timed; Bourdieu argues that the social organization of a society around clock time rests on the consent of people in that society to abide by it (2014). Time is furthermore embedded within culture, and people’s meaning-making both reproduces and modifies cultural narratives and expectations about time. This is especially apparent in contexts of “hysteresis” (Bourdieu, 2010), or dissonance between temporal expectations and their realities. Meaning-making can smooth over such disjuncture or amplify it. If amplified, disjuncture between temporal expectations and present realities can result in the withdrawal of consent to structures of time—even to their abolition. For example, the ten-day calendar instituted in France following the French Revolution lasted only a short while because of how completely it conflicted with the existing social organization and symbolism of time (Tavory & Eliasoph, 2013; Zerubavel, 1977). However, individuals’ meaning-making, as shown in studies of temporality in flexible capitalism, can also mend the gap between temporal expectation and reality (Ayala-Hurtado, 2022; Snyder, 2016).

In turn, how people negotiate the meaning and organization of time in their lives shapes how temporal practices unfold in work settings. Following the implementation of a four-day workweek at one company, staff used a

range of strategies to reorganize their work time, many of which involved changing how they thought about their time (Moen & Chu, 2023). A study of responses to work hour limits in hospitals also highlights the role of meaning-making in outcomes, especially in regards to the formation of coalitions opposing or supporting the new policy (Kellogg, 2011). Meanwhile, an ethnographic analysis of a graduate student's management of teaching and research responsibilities shows the interactive improvisation that must be done to reconcile these competing temporal demands (Gepts, 2024).

This paper extends the body of work on the micro-sociological negotiation of work time through the site of restaurant work. This industry serves as an example of a precarious, relatively low-wage work setting, in which work is conducted in close proximity and coordination with other workplace actors. This site offers a useful window into the contextual factors and processes that lead the paradigm of flexibility to be challenged or upheld.

I examine a case where economic and social disruption have offered the potential for meanings and practices around time to change within work settings. In contrast to the widespread job loss characterizing the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, later periods of the pandemic were characterized by a tight labor market. In this context, workers had "marketplace bargaining power" (Silver, 2006; Wright, 2000); workers had structural power relative to employers due to demand for labor outstripping supply. While early pandemic conditions led to feelings of loss of control over hours for some workers (Fan & Moen, 2022), we should expect to see improvements to workers' scheduling conditions in contexts under competitive labor market conditions (Newman & Jacobs, 2023). However, researchers have found varied patterns in workers' experiences of scheduling in tight labor markets. One team of researchers, employing survey data from workers collected between 2017 and 2021, found little change in workers' scheduling conditions pre- and post-pandemic (Zundl et al., 2022). Others, however, have found evidence of employers adapting workplace schedules since the pandemic in order to better meet the preferences of workers (Newman & Jacobs, 2023). Additionally, a study drawing on 1995–2017 data posits that work hour volatility decreases with tight labor markets, especially for low-wage workers (LaBriola & Schneider, 2020). The present paper speaks to the puzzle of these mixed results by looking closely at the mechanisms through which employers and workers negotiate the flexibility paradigm amidst conditions of worker power.

Simultaneously, the pandemic, lockdown measures, and subsequent changes in the economy disrupted the typical rhythms of life for many people. Scholars have found that some precarious and low-wage workers, who often work in flexibly organized workplaces, reevaluated the meaning

of time in their lives during this time, for example by prioritizing family, turning down or deprioritizing work, or by investing their work time in more passion-driven pursuits (Ravenelle & Kowalski, 2022; Schieman et al., 2022). This paper goes inside flexibly organized workplaces to see how such understandings of work time have since unfolded.

Three Dimensions of Work Time: A Framework

In this context, I examine the micro-sociological construction of work time through three lenses on work time that are derived from scholarly literature as well as themes I identified within my data: work time as a *site of power*, as a *moral entity*, and as a *relational entity*.²

First, thinking of time as a site of workplace power means recognizing that it is a finite resource that is constantly under negotiation between employers and workers. As Clawson and Gerstel (2014) argue, employers and workers often have opposing wishes when it comes to time: employers wish workers would work when the *business* wants them to, and workers wish they could work when *they* want to. Time has been an important mechanism of the commodification and control of modern labor (Marx, 1978; Snyder, 2016; Thompson, 1967), as shown amply by the history of scientific management or Taylorism, in which time studies aimed to maximize efficiency and profit through the control of labor. Time studies, which literally involved timing workers' movements amidst production tasks, assisted employers in the breaking down of work into ever smaller components by harvesting workers' embodied expertise. In turn, time studies helped managers claim authority over the way work should be done and engineer speed-ups of work processes (Braverman, 1976; Cappelli, 1999; Snyder, 2016).

Flexible scheduling presents opportunities for workers seeking jobs with "nonstandard" schedules. In low-wage work, however, flexible scheduling tends to ultimately be employer-driven, though employers may blend more and less obvious means of schedule control. In the age of flexible capitalism, employers have gone to new heights to synchronize workers' schedules with demand, leading to the rise of just-in-time scheduling (Lambert, Henly & Kim, 2019). Drawing on cases such as kitchen work and retail, scholars argue that flexible scheduling is not only a tool for maximizing workplace productivity and cutting labor costs but also of labor control and of the obfuscation of workplace power relations (Halpin, 2015; Wood, 2020). Halpin (2015) argues that the "mock schedule," or the official schedule that is nonetheless subject to significant manipulation by managers in response to demand, is a tool that gives workers the illusion of predictability despite the lack of control over the schedule that they really experience. Offering

flexibility to workers can also act as a labor control; as seen among taxi drivers, workers may feel they have autonomy when they feel like they have control over their schedules, even when the concrete tasks they perform are driven by demand (Occhiuto, 2017). Amazon, in turn, an emblematic site of contemporary precarious work, blends more coercive, obviously employer-driven flexible scheduling practices with ones that offer flexibility to workers to help reduce labor costs (Vallas et al., 2022). An eye on power in flexible scheduling contexts helps illumine the nuances of scheduling's relationship to labor control.

Time's nature as a *moral entity* interacts with the relationship between work time and power. Here, I employ a definition of morality as "ideas and feelings regarding how people should behave, particularly with respect to others, in relation to their well-being" (Sayer, 2010, p. 164). Morality also includes "thick understandings [...] about what kind of person (or society) it is good to be" (Hitlin & Vaisey, 2013, p. 55). In other words, I consider the domain of morality to encompass not just people's ideas about right and wrong, but also their aspirations and dreams in pursuit of good, dignified, and meaningful lives (Snyder, 2013).

Time spent at work has long had a moral dimension. In fact, in the West, the keeping of chronological time itself, or a notion of time as linear, evenly spaced, and precisely measurable, has its origins in Christian communal religious life: schedules developed as tools to coordinate group prayer, and the mechanical clock as a tool to follow the prayer schedule of the Divine Office, a set of daily, timed prayers (Snyder, 2016). As observed by Weber (1976) in communities with Protestant heritage, the link between hard work and virtue emerged from religious practice but secularized over time. In the factory era, when pay became measured by hours, the association between time at work and morality persisted: "[employers] were able to legitimize their support for regularized and intensified labor by appealing directly to the now ancient tradition of chronological time as a stern moral guide" (Snyder, 2016, p. 37). Ideas about the moralizing effects of time spent working endure; perhaps most starkly, this is visible in the coerced labor of incarcerated people (Hatton, 2019).

The morality of work and work time is also embedded in social structures like gender, citizenship, and class. Structure shapes the life circumstances in which people find themselves and conditions the cultural schemas from which they construct meaning, including moral schemas (Blair-Loy, 2010; Gomberg-Muñoz, 2010). Women today are subject to cultural, morally-infused schemas which promote devotion to family on one hand and devotion to paid work on the other (Blair-Loy, 2003, 2010; Damaske, 2011). Meanwhile, the moral discourses of men about work, especially in

studies of working-class men, emphasize values like responsibility at work and reflect cultural schemas of men as providers (Lamont, 2000). Simultaneously, immigrant, especially undocumented, men's cultivation of the "hard worker" identity serves as a source of dignity in the poor quality jobs to which they are typically restricted (Gomberg-Muñoz, 2019). Socially structured identities are likely to shape moral conceptions of work time.

Studies have shed some light on the role of morality in workers' experiences of time in flexible scheduling and low-wage contexts, but more remains to be uncovered. Snyder's (2016) work points to the ambiguous relationship between flexible scheduling and "the good life"; for workers in industries like trucking, the temporal organization of the job promotes a sense of autonomy, and some workers find pride and dignity in managing the flexible demands of the job. However, such jobs can pose challenges to dignity as well, as when the temporal demands of trucking leave workers feeling like "robots" (Snyder, 2016, p. 123). In low-wage women's work, meanwhile, the moral imperative of caregiving drives mothers' attempts to control their schedules (Dodson, 2007), which is an important site of claims-making among some immigrant women workers as well (Tenorio, 2023). Studies also show that morality shapes workers' interactions with other workplace actors regarding the schedule, as I discuss below. However, the role of morality in experiences of flexible scheduling merits further exploration—including the interaction of the morality of time with time's embeddedness in power relations.

Finally, time in the workplace is also experienced *relationally* with regard to other workplace actors. This view is implied in and closely related to the power and morality frameworks but merits its own discussion. Drawing on their study of schedule unpredictability in healthcare work, Clawson and Gerstel view work time, specifically schedules, as being constituted by the "web of time," or the collective relations "within occupations and organizations as well as across them, within families, and among them" (Clawson & Gerstel, 2014, p. 6). Because time in organizations is collective, "changes in one person's schedule cascade to create changes in the schedule of another person at the workplace and outside of it. The subsequent meshing of schedules leads to cooperation and accommodation, struggle and conflict—between employees and supervisors, among coworkers, between regular workers and per diems, among different organizations, between spouses, parents, and children, and with other kin" (Clawson & Gerstel, 2014, p. 6). The relational nature of work time may be especially salient in contexts with a "time discipline" of coordination, where workers' action and movement in space are meant to be tightly interrelated (Glennie & Thrift, 1996).

Indeed, research on other contexts with “nonstandard” hours suggests that relationships between coworkers as well as workers and managers are consequential for workers’ experiences with scheduling, in ways that interact with the power-related and moral aspects of work time. Wilson (2019, 2020) describes how schedule swapping among restaurant workers helps them express agency over their schedules and is enabled through social embeddedness in the workplace. In retail workplaces, Wood (2020) argues that managers’ granting of schedule requests to workers acts as a kind of “gift” that produces obligation among workers to their managers, following the social (and moral) codes associated with gift-giving. Successful pushback to demands for flexibility is also more likely where strong coalitions that share a similar view of work time are able to form and support each other in claims-making (Kellogg, 2011). These findings suggest the importance of attention to flexible scheduling as being embedded within the social relations of the workplace.

I bring together these three frames—the power, moral, and relational dimensions of time—to shed light on how individuals interact with and shape temporal ideals and practices in precarious and low-wage work.

The Case of Restaurant Work

Restaurant work offers a useful lens into the workings of the flexible economy. The dominant time discipline of restaurant work is geared towards flexibility and demand, mirroring the dynamics of flexible capitalism more broadly—though, as accounts of early twentieth century restaurant work demonstrate, it predates it (Cobble, 1992). In this system, work time is shaped by demand; while workers can carve out some flexibility, they do so within limitations.

Restaurant workers’ schedules are set by managers. By the nature of the service they provide, restaurant hours often clash with the dominant rhythms of society: restaurant workers often labor late nights and weekends, when others are in their hours of leisure. Weekend availability is often a requirement for restaurant jobs. Extant research has documented that schedules may vary from week to week and may be posted with little notice (Fine, 1996; Wilson, 2019, 2020). Demand and last-minute managerial decisions dynamically shape work time. Workers may either be “cut” (the practice of managers ending their shifts early) or alternately asked to work longer than they had expected depending on factors like customer volume or how long customers stay at the end of the night (Haley-Lock, 2012; Halpin, 2015; Henly & Lambert, 2014). Cutting helps employers reduce labor costs (Haley-Lock, 2012), and among tipped workers helps protect the pay of

the employees who remain at work. However, unpredictable scheduling and last-minute changes to schedules can be disruptive for workers, including unforeseen impacts on their pay.³ Before the pandemic, workers were also often expected to work even when sick or injured (Carpenter et al., 2013; Clayton et al., 2015; Gleeson, 2012). Low levels of paid time off, sick leave, or family leave across the restaurant industry have meant that workers' pay depends on the hours they can physically show up to work. Several studies have shown that workers fear repercussions from their managers due to calling out sick or going home when injured (Carpenter et al., 2013; Clayton et al., 2015; Gleeson, 2012).

Restaurant workers have various ways of interpreting and negotiating this system of work time. Some strategies of schedule control include swapping shifts, lengthening shifts to increase pay, and drawing on seniority and relationships with managers (Wilson, 2020). Additionally, a sense of control can come from the meaning that workers assign to their schedules. Many "lead" front of the house workers, like servers and bartenders, consider their jobs to be flexible and amenable to other pursuits like other jobs or hobbies (Wilson, 2019). In turn, several studies have documented how working long, hard hours can be a source of meaning and pride for restaurant workers (Carpenter et al., 2013; Gleeson, 2012; Wilson, 2020). However, a lack of truly employee-driven flexibility creates financial and other costs for restaurant workers and their families (Henly & Lambert, 2014; Jacobs & Padavic, 2015; Lambert et al., 2012; Lambert, Henly & Kim, 2019). Workers' social location interplays with these experiences of work time, as harder-driving norms around work time and effort have been observed in occupational niches that are coded as masculine and/or immigrant work, like kitchen work and support work (Fine, 1996; Gomberg-Muñoz, 2019; Halpin, 2015; Wilson, 2020). Meanwhile, Wilson's (2020) study of fine dining work found that the ability to "flex" schedules was especially prized by non-immigrant, front of the house restaurant workers, who were often white with middle-class backgrounds.

The restaurant work literature offers a useful point of comparison for examining practices and meaning-making around flexible work time in pandemic-era work. After describing my data and methods, I will discuss how the paradigm of flexible work time was challenged as well as upheld in restaurants during this time of disruption.

Data and Methods

This paper draws from a qualitative study of pandemic-era restaurant work in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, primarily drawing on ethnography and

qualitative interviews. I worked in a restaurant for over a year between 2021 and 2022, where I conducted participant observation. Formal, qualitative interviews were conducted with a total of 93 people: 24 people who had worked at my field site and 69 additional people, who were all working or had recently worked in other restaurants in the city. I conducted non-participant observation at an additional restaurant, and I took ethnographic field notes about my interviews and visits to participants' workplaces. This study was approved by the Institutional Review Board of Temple University. All participants and businesses have been assigned pseudonyms, and minor details have been changed in a few cases to provide an extra layer of protection for participants.

I conducted participant observation at a restaurant where I worked from August 2021 to September 2022. "El Amigo," a pseudonym, is a restaurant serving Mexican cuisine, largely catering to a middle-class, non-Latinx clientele in a trendy Philadelphia neighborhood. I worked at the restaurant for thirteen months total, and I formally conducted research for approximately nine months; I decided to make the restaurant my study site after having worked there for several months. Once I had made this decision, I obtained consent for the research by explaining the study to my managers and coworkers and asking for their agreement to being included in the research. I explained I would anonymize the business as well as participants. I did this on an ongoing basis as new staff was hired. After securing the consent of managers and coworkers, I took detailed, ethnographic field notes.

During my time at the restaurant, I worked as a food runner, host, and server, for approximately three shifts per week, which varied in length but usually lasted six to seven hours. While my firsthand experience of the job (and of scheduling) was as a front of the house worker, the variety of my roles allowed me to observe dynamics in both the front of the house and back of the house, as well as to form relationships throughout the restaurant. This was especially important given that El Amigo, like many restaurant workplaces, was marked by the occupational segregation of restaurant workers by race and nativity (Restaurant Opportunities Center United, 2014; Wilson, 2020). As a white, US-born woman, it was easiest for me to "fit in" socially with the predominantly white and non-immigrant front of the house staff. However, I also cultivated relationships with back of the house coworkers and managers, almost all of whom were first-generation immigrants from Mexico, Honduras, and Guatemala. I was aided by my proficiency in Spanish, as well as by being stationed in the kitchen as a food runner, where I worked across from the line cooks, taking the orders of food they prepared out into the dining area or packaging them for takeout. I also often hung out in the back of the house during downtime, fetched

sodas and waters for the kitchen staff during my food runner shifts, and chatted with coworkers there when I was able, about work as well as life.

At El Amigo, there was somewhat less gender segregation than has been observed in other restaurant workplaces (see Harris & Giuffre, 2015), such that there were other women also working in the kitchen and roughly equal numbers of men and women on the front of the house team. Overall, the staff was a blend of experienced and “greener” workers, skewing somewhat towards people for whom restaurant work was their full-time job, though significant turnover occurred throughout the period of my employment.

Participant observation was complemented by formal interviews with 93 people. As mentioned, slightly more than a quarter of these were conducted with people who were working or had worked at my field site, while 69 interviews were conducted with workers and managers/owners at other restaurants. While an in-depth study of one workplace helped me observe processes and people’s real-time behavior, interviews with participants from other businesses helped me triangulate and contextualize data from my field site, while also providing wider insight into restaurant workers’ and managers’ thoughts and feelings. Almost all interviewees were actively employed in the restaurant industry at the time of the research, given the research’s focus on ongoing conditions in restaurant work. Some participants had worked for the same employer since before the pandemic, but others had changed jobs and employers, yielding a rich data set about experiences in over 100 restaurants. I focused on people involved in full-service restaurant work, or work in restaurants where service primarily takes place at a customer’s table rather than at a counter. To attempt to capture a robust sample, I sampled workers and managers in both front of the house and back of the house roles as well as across various restaurant price points (e.g., from diners to fine dining).

Interviewees were recruited through diverse methods, including fieldwork, snowball sampling, direct outreach to businesses, and referrals from a worker advocacy organization. I conducted most interviews, with a smaller number conducted by Spanish-speaking research assistants.⁴ Participants were compensated \$30 for participation in a research interview. Interviewers obtained informed, verbal consent from interviewees. Following this, interviewers followed a semi-structured interview protocol that covered participants’ experiences within the restaurant industry, participants’ most recent job(s), their experiences during COVID-19, especially in the context of work, and their perceptions and feelings about these topics. Most interviews lasted between an hour and an hour and a half in length. Brief follow-up conversations were conducted with a handful of participants, especially those who had been interviewed early in the research process. Interviews were conducted

in-person, over Zoom, or over the phone, depending on respondents' preferences and ongoing pandemic conditions; also, one participant was interviewed over email. All interviewees consented to interviews being audio-recorded, except one manager who was uncomfortable with being recorded and the participant who communicated via email. Interviews were either transcribed through an automated transcription program and manually edited for accuracy, or they were transcribed by a professional transcriptionist. Spanish-language interviews were professionally transcribed and translated to English, and quotations that were originally in Spanish are presented in both languages in this paper.

Table 1 lists a summary of demographic and other relevant characteristics of interview participants. Participants ranged in age from 19–61, and men and women were about equally represented, with a small number of non-binary workers participating. About 41 percent of participants were non-Hispanic white, with 34.4 percent identifying as Latinx or Hispanic, 18.3 identifying as non-Hispanic Black or African American, and small percentages identifying as multiracial and Asian. Black and Asian restaurant workers are underrepresented in the sample, likely due to the underrepresentation of Black workers in front of the house work in full-service restaurants, while the network referrals I used to connect with back of the house workers tended to lead me to Latinx workers. Foreign-born workers comprised 29 percent of the sample. About 39 percent were parents. About 60 percent of the sample had not completed a four-year college degree. Around the time of the pandemic and the research, 64.5 percent of participants primarily worked in full-service restaurants with a two-dollar sign price point on Google (which I conceptualized as being the mid-range of the restaurant market), while 29 percent worked in businesses with higher price points (fine dining); workers and managers from businesses with lower price points were underrepresented.

My analysis consisted of an iterative process of repeatedly listening to interviews and reading interview transcripts, interview memos, and my field notes from participant observation, followed by generating analytical memos that reflected on topics of interest (Lareau, 2021). I then engaged in several cycles of recoding, writing, reading relevant literature, and writing some more. While I approached the data with some pre-determined codes in mind, I also engaged in open coding (Emerson et al., 2011).

The following analysis focuses on worker and managers' experiences during later stages of the pandemic. While I had taken interest in restaurant workers' experiences during earlier stages of the pandemic, which began in March 2020, I formally began collecting data in the summer of 2021. In Philadelphia, this coincided with the lifting of several restrictions that had

Table 1. Interview Participant Characteristics (*n* = 93).

	Frequency	Percent
Age		
19–35	61	65.6
36–50	27	29.0
51 +	5	5.4
Gender		
Man	46	49.5
Woman	44	47.3
Non-binary	3	3.2
Race/ethnicity		
White	38	40.9
Latinx/Hispanic	32	34.4
Black/African American	17	18.3
More than one race	5	5.4
Asian	1	1.1
Immigrant		
Yes	27	29.0
No	66	71.0
Parent		
Yes	36	38.7
No	57	61.3
Education		
High school or less	22	23.7
Some college or trade school	34	36.6
4-year degree	26	28.0
Some graduate school or graduate degree	5	5.4
Missing ^a	6	6.5
Primary type of restaurant works in (by price point)*[^]		
\$	12	12.9
\$\$	60	64.5
\$\$\$ +	27	29.0
Other ^b	7	7.5
Type of work performed*[^]		
Front of the house	41	44.1
Back of the house	36	38.7
Manager	32	34.4
Owner	2	2.2
Worked in restaurants during/since the pandemic		
Yes	86	92.5
No	7	7.5

(continued)

Table 1. Continued.

	Frequency	Percent
Worked at the field site		
Yes	24	25.8
No	69	74.2

*Around the time of the pandemic.
^Values may not add up to 100% due to participants who had more than one job over study period.
^Missing values reflect participants whose educational attainment is unknown.
^Counter service restaurant or catering.

been implemented to promote COVID safety in businesses like restaurants, such as indoor dining restrictions and mask mandates. For the most part, restrictions continued to be eased throughout the remainder of my data collection. The timing of my research thus positioned me to observe processes through which restaurants “returned to normal” as well as the emergence of alternative practices.

Findings

Next, I apply the framework of work time as an object of power, morality, and relationality to workplace experiences during later stages of the pandemic. Using this framework, I examine ways that the paradigm of temporal flexibility was both contested and reproduced in a context of relative worker power as well as social disruption.

Time and Power: Higher Bargaining Power Boosts Worker Control Over Flexibility

The relative power of workers compared to employers played a major role in participants’ experiences of work time during this period. On the whole, due to the tight labor market seen in the aftermath of the pandemic, workers experienced marketplace bargaining power (Silver, 2006; Wright, 2000). Workers’ heightened power was one factor shaping scheduling experiences, though this power has appeared to wane with recovery from the pandemic.

In the period following the gradual reopening of restaurants for table service in the summer of 2020, there were widespread perceptions of a “worker shortage.” Nationally, following a spike at the onset of the pandemic, the rate of unemployed people relative to job openings fell sharply by summer

2020; it fell to the pre-pandemic low of 0.7 by September 2021, reflecting a higher number of job openings relative to the number of unemployed people, and kept falling throughout much of the following year (Tashiro & Wardrip, 2023). In Philadelphia, the number of people in the labor force dropped to 725,022 in April 2020, overall kept trending downward until hitting a low of 714,805 in December 2021, and subsequently did not surpass pre-pandemic numbers until February 2023 (Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2024). The leisure and hospitality labor market, one setting where these trends played out, faced a surplus of jobs relative to workers willing to take them. As of February 2023, about 500,000 leisure and hospitality jobs nationally remained unfilled relative to 2020 levels (Bhattarai & Penman, 2023). COVID-related death and disability, early retirement, job changes, and (until fall 2021) the availability of economic relief for pandemic unemployment left holes in the workforce that employers scrambled to fill even years after the onset of the pandemic. Ongoing staffing challenges were even mentioned during some interviews conducted in 2023, three years after the pandemic began.

In this context, the workers who *would* work had leverage, because it was more difficult to replace them than in a typical labor market. The fact that I was even hired at my field site in 2021 despite lacking restaurant experience (and, embarrassingly, showing up late to my job interview due to bad traffic) speaks to the condition of the labor market at the time of my research. Restaurant managers and owners spoke openly with me about the power that the labor market offered workers over their schedules. Peter, a white upper-level manager in his 40s, said, “we had no leverage in the conversation all the time [...] it’s an employee’s world in a lot of ways these days, as opposed to an employer’s world.” Emma, a white manager at my field site who was in her 30s, contrasted this state of affairs with the previous status quo: “I think that it has changed in the sense of before, you could be much more like your schedule is your schedule, take it or leave it.” Illustrating this shift in power, at a managers-only scheduling meeting I observed at my field site, I noted that managers weighed workers’ scheduling preferences a good deal, discussing one worker’s return to school, proactive concerns that another may be “burnt out” and working too many days, and another’s request to have off on Fridays, one of the busiest nights at the restaurant (“she’s put in the work, she deserves it,” Emma said, defending the worker).⁵

One way that workers exercised their leverage was by limiting how much they worked. Khalil, a Black chef in his 40s, recounted that applicants would offer only limited availability: “I can only work these hours and this day and this or this.” Noah, a Black bartender and server in his 30s, was one such worker. While recovering from an injury, he got a job at my field site, and

found the employers to be flexible around his limited availability: “[the restaurant] is nice, [the restaurant] is good. They worked with me through my injury. Like when I was like I can only work this day, they were like, yeah okay.” While Noah was an experienced worker who had previously worked at the same restaurant, he had been concerned that employers would be reluctant to hire someone who was hurt, and he even left his crutches at home the day of his job interview though he needed them. However, he readily found employment, despite the injury and his limited availability. The staffing shortage offered leverage to workers like him who could or would only work limited hours.

Conversely, some workers leveraged the labor market situation to work as many hours as they would like. For example, Tina, a Latina support worker and server in her 40s, said that there were plenty of hours available during this time. “Back then, ‘oh, please work more! Could you [work] more hours?’” Tina liked having the ability to work as much as she wanted, on the days and times she liked. “It was good, yeah. No complaints because it was the hours I wanted, the days I wanted. They were very flexible back then.” In contrast, by 2023, when workers’ marketplace bargaining power had weakened, Tina noted in a follow-up interview that her employers were putting caps on workers’ hours to save costs.

Changes in practices around requesting time off also reflected the shift in workers’ power. While workers told me that before, taking time off work without finding a replacement was generally unthinkable, I witnessed workers taking time off without offering a replacement during my fieldwork, and I frequently heard about it happening in other restaurants. In the front of the house, managers at my field site felt it was enough of an issue to send a message to all staff: “hey everyone, just a reminder that requests off are still something you need to find coverage for [...] If you put in a request off, we still need you guys to make the effort of finding coverage for your shift.” Still, on many occasions, I witnessed managers rather than workers taking on the labor of looking for people to cover workers’ shifts.

Across the restaurants where participants worked, callouts were also reportedly more frequent than before the pandemic. Rich, a white chef in his 30s, felt he had limited room to push back against callouts because of the limited labor pool: “everyone’s calling out all the time and just being like, oh, yeah, I just can’t work today. Like, I just don’t feel like it. And you’re like, okay, because you need them to come back in the next day.” The context of the pandemic helped legitimize workers’ use of sick days, which contributed to callouts. Dennis, a Black line cook in his 30s, explained:

Before, especially for cooks, if you were sick, your ass was still working. Unless you physically couldn’t do something, “don’t care, come in here.”

But now with everything, it's like, "oh, you're sick. No, stay home. Don't come in. If you get me sick, I'm going to freak out."

These dynamics offered leverage to workers over their work time and to achieve some measure of employee-driven flexibility more easily than before the pandemic.

Despite the relative power of workers, employers still demanded temporal flexibility in certain situations. Garnering the consent of workers by honoring their scheduling preferences was a mechanism of labor control, but one that could compromise the integrity of the labor process and result in managers themselves personally filling in "on the floor."⁶ In some contexts, managers made more despotic demands on workers' time. However, such demands could generate resistance. Juliana, a Latina woman in her 30s, worked for a manager who sent food orders to the kitchen after it had already closed, delaying the time that kitchen staff could leave work. One day, however, Juliana pushed back and confronted the manager.

One day [it] was 1:05 am, we [had] cleaned everything and he sent [an order]. I said we are not making [it] because we close the kitchen at 1. And he came to me yelling, and he told me, "I'm the manager and you do what I said, if I want to close kitchen later I can do it." So I get furious, and I told him, you are wrong, we have a life.

Previously, in fact, Juliana reported, the staff had even had a meeting about the schedule with another one of her bosses, who explained that the restaurant closed at 12:30 AM, the kitchen closed at 1 AM, and no more food was to be made after 1 AM. In response to Juliana's attempt to enforce this schedule, the manager gave Juliana further trouble: "[the] next day he tried to talk shit about me, and since then he was a dick to me." In the fallout of this incident, Juliana quit her job; luckily, however, she readily found another, higher-ranking job within a different restaurant company.

Not all workers necessarily felt they had more power over their schedules. Mothers especially had mixed experiences with scheduling in later stages of the pandemic, due to conflicts between childcare needs and the demands of the workplace. Some, like Alejandra, a Latina woman in her 30s, found accommodation. A line cook, she successfully pushed back on management when they wanted to change which days she had time off: "they wanted to change it and I said no, I can't have off [on other days] because I have to take my children to their appointments [me lo quisieron mover y yo les dije que no, no puedo estar descansando porque tengo que llevar a mis hijos a sus citas]." Others faced challenges obtaining flexibility from

employers. For example, Silvia, a Latina line cook in her 20s who worked at my field site, had to quit her job due to a lack of accommodations for her caregiving needs. During the summer months, Silvia could not make it to work on time for her shift. She had to pick her daughter up from summer school, where her daughter, recently arrived from Mexico, was getting a boost to her English skills. No one else could pick up Silvia's daughter, as Silvia's husband worked afternoons, and they didn't have friends or family nearby who could help. Rather than accommodating her, Silvia's boss, the chef, didn't budge: "he wants me to come at five, but I would come at 6 [quiere que yo viniera a las 5 pero yo vendría a las 6]," Silvia explained to me, frustration tinged her voice as she described the situation. Notably, this occurred in the summer of 2022, at a point when staffing the kitchen was getting easier.

For the most part, however, in the pandemic context, experiences of work time reflected the relative power of workers during this period. A tight labor market offered structural power to workers, which enabled them to gain relatively greater control over their work time and demands for flexibility. However, rather than being totally transformed, the paradigm of employer-driven flexibility underwent both resistance and reproduction. Attention to the moral and relational aspects of time, and their relationship to power and to each other, helps explicate these patterns.

Moral Lenses as Sources of Consent and Tools of Resistance to Flexible Scheduling Practices

Workers' scheduling experiences were also shaped by moral attitudes towards work time. Again, I conceptualize morality as both people's ideas about right and wrong, especially in relation to how they treat others as well as what makes a good, dignified, and meaningful life (Hitlin & Vaisey, 2013; Sayer, 2010; Snyder, 2016). Moral lenses shaped workers' scheduling preferences and practices and helped them construct meaning around their schedules. Some workers drew on dominant moral lenses that largely aligned with employer-driven flexibility. However, a context of heightened worker power helped workers also mobilize moral lenses that pushed back on employer-driven flexibility. In other words, a way that workers resisted employer power over scheduling was through moral arguments. Moral lenses, in turn, were also one way that managers pushed back on heightened worker power.

Some workers mobilized a frame of personal responsibility to interpret demands on their schedules. Walter, a Latino food runner in his 40s who worked at my field site, had a strong moral identity as a dependable

worker; in his own words, “I am a responsible working person and I don’t like to let work down [soy persona de trabajo responsable y no me gusta fallar al trabajo].” This identity was part of Walter’s broader self-concept as a good worker—evident in the stories he’d proudly tell me about how beloved he had been at a previous restaurant, or the variety of dishes he had worked on during his morning job as a prep cook. Walter’s moral framing of work time helped him interpret the demands of the workplace in a positive light. One time, he tried to take a day off on short notice to attend a family gathering. Managers denied his request, and the next time I saw him at work, I asked him about it.

He didn’t seem beat up about it and explained understandingly, “Emma [the manager] was worried [se preocupaba]”; “they really needed me here [aquí me necesitaban bastante].” And his relative called off the party last minute, so there was no conflict in the end.

Even though the scheduling conflict had been averted, I was struck by how accepting Walter’s reaction was, given that he had made the effort of talking to two different managers to request time off (enlisting me as an interpreter the second time). Walter, however, had made sense of the denial of his request for time off through the moral lens of being a dependable worker.

Other workers also called on identities as responsible workers in reacting to work’s demands on their time. Yanet, a Latina cook in her 30s at El Amigo, said that she came to work one day despite back pain so bad that it was hard to move “because I’m responsible. I don’t like to [not] come.” Beau, a Black server and bartender in his 30s, described complying with a last-minute request to take a shift as a reflection of his reliability. He described a call from his boss: “‘We don’t have a bartender this morning. Is there any way?’ I’m like, that’s fine, here I come. I’ve always been a reliable employee. Do you need me? I’ll do my best to get there.” Responsibility to the job shaped these workers’ time practices, e.g., not taking time off despite an injury in Yanet’s case, and picking up a last minute shift in Beau’s.

For immigrant men in particular, and especially those with plans to return to their home countries and without family in the U.S., dreams of a “good life” in home countries gave both practical and moral motivation to workers to work as much as they could, and to accede to demands on their time. Rubén, a cook in his 40s from Mexico, reflected about his time in the US apart from his children:

When I got here, I missed them a lot, I cried and everything, but time went by, and I said: “well, I’m here now, well, *échale ganas* [give it all you’ve got],

right?" I came to work, that's why I came, so they could study, to build them a house, all of that [...] So I came here, yes, to work hard, so they would be a little better off.

[Llegando aquí les extrañé mucho, lloraba y eso, pero fue pasando el tiempo y dije: "pues ya estoy aquí, pues, échale ganas", ¿no? A trabajar, por eso vine, para que estudiaran, para hacerles una casita, todo eso [...] Entonces vine aquí, sí, a echarle ganas para que ellos estuvieran un poquito mejor.]

For fathers and husbands who endured the challenges of immigration, supporting a family abroad was a practical and moral end that animated their aspirations to work hard and gave meaning to often very demanding schedules. Rubén worked 55 hours a week. Other immigrant men in this study who were supporting family abroad worked at similar or greater rates; Luis, a coworker of mine in his 20s, juggled two full-time schedules.⁷

Meanwhile, for other workers, seeing flexibility as part of the "good life" encouraged alignment with employers' demands for workers' flexibility and availability. Beau, the server and bartender mentioned earlier, worked "16–18 hours days, 6 days a week," splitting time between two restaurants, a job for an interior design company, and his own personal design consulting work. Beau framed the juggling of these jobs as both necessity and choice. On one hand, Beau had multiple income streams—"for security reasons, because one day I'll make \$320, the next day I'll make \$16. You just never know. It's so unpredictable." However, Beau also said he enjoyed work that let him pick up or drop a shift when he wanted—one that let him find "balance," an arrangement he called "perfect."

Just knowing my lifestyle, I don't think I'm ever going to find this balance anywhere else. Like I would always do my [design job] in the daytime, and then have my serving or bartending job at night. It was perfect. I can pick up shifts, or if I can't make a scheduled shift, you know, there's the option to release it, there's 30 other servers waiting to pick it up. So I really can't have that flexibility with a nine to five, per se.

Beau's positive spin on the "flexibility" of restaurant work presents a vision of flexibility as part of a good, desirable life, similar to young adults' investment in the flexibility of restaurant work in other studies (Wilson, 2019). Notably, Beau's willingness to pick up shifts last-minute as a "reliable employee," mentioned earlier, is the other side of his ability to drop shifts as needed.

Other times, however, workers drew on moral frames that pushed back on employer-driven flexibility. Moral frames were a way that workers resisted employer control over time, and the shift in power relations between workers and employers helped give these frames weight. For example, Skyler, a white cook in their 20s who worked in fine dining, pursued the moral end of “work–life balance.” Skyler used to derive a sense of pride from the fast pace and extensive temporal demands of back of the house work:

When I first started working, I was like, I’m so hardworking. I worked six days a week, I busted my ass, I made 10 [dollars] an hour, and I was doing whatever shitty job they wanted me to do. And I hated my life, but I also I felt that back of the house pride.

However, they said, “at this point in my life, I don’t really see that to be something to be proud of. I think that’s lame.” After being laid off at the beginning of the pandemic, they went back to work in the summer of 2020, where overwork and the risks of COVID killed Skyler’s pride in their work and their willingness to work long hours. “My priorities shifted a lot during the pandemic,” Skyler explained, mentioning their desire to spend time with their family as well as valuing their body. “I think people are realizing that capitalism is a scam, and you don’t have to break your back every day because at the end of it, you’re going to be retired in a coma, or my carpal tunnel is going to ruin my life.” In turn, Skyler tried to keep their work schedule to four days a week. At one job they had success with this, but at another, because of staffing issues, Skyler worked five days a week. However, Skyler planned to quit this job, their moral vision of time outweighing their desire to keep the job.

Zaire, a Black line cook in his 20s, used the “work–life balance” framework as well as a frame of dignity to make claims on his time. Zaire wanted to own his own restaurant one day and had a passion for food, but he was also a very engaged college student who made sure he had three days off from work every week. Around the time of our interview, Zaire’s manager asked him to come in on two Wednesdays in a row, which was normally a day off for Zaire—one week the manager had a medical procedure, and the following he was going on vacation. On one hand, Zaire expressed sympathy for the work–life balance needs of managers: “I don’t want a manager never to see their kids because they’ve been working so much.” However, he described being asked to work on his days off—particularly for two consecutive weeks, and particularly the week the manager was on vacation—as “irresponsible and disrespectful.”

I filled in for him this last Wednesday, and then I get a text today, he's like hey, can you come in this Wednesday? And I was like sorry, I can't. Not to be spiteful, I can't. We all need to have a good work-life balance and I think whenever a manager or an owner asks that of their employees without putting as much effort in, that is directly irresponsible and disrespectful.

Zaire's interpretation of these events reflects his own vision of a life well-lived, as well as moral expectations towards his employers to respect *him* by honoring his scheduling preferences.

Additionally, for parents whose children resided with them, especially mothers, the moral imperative of caregiving gave impetus to some workers to push back on employers' demands for their time. Natalie, a white server in her 30s, lived this struggle. Natalie had a daughter in elementary school, and spending time with her had long shaped Natalie's decision-making, even leading Natalie to leave other restaurant jobs because they made her miss holidays and her daughter's birthday: "I decided that I was not ever gonna do that to her." Natalie came to work at El Amigo, my field site, after being told she could have the schedule she wanted: just Saturday and Sunday brunch, so she could spend ample time with her daughter. However, due to staffing challenges, managers would often ask Natalie to take extra shifts. Natalie told me, "I would like to help and take more days while [my daughter is] at school"; however, she faced scheduling conflicts, as despite her husband's help, she was often the parent picking their daughter up from school. Furthermore, Natalie strongly felt it was important to perform this duty herself, rather than asking for help from nearby family: "I've just always been the kind of parent that's like, I'm not gonna force my kid on somebody else because I feel like doing whatever I want to do. I had a kid, you know what I mean? It's my responsibility. She's only gonna be little for so long." Natalie thus experienced tension between being a good worker and a good mother.

Natalie grew frustrated with work's last-minute requests on her time: "I don't mind if you ask me, then I can prepare not just physically but mentally to stay there for 11, 12, however many hours you need me, I'll stay there 24 hours, but I need to know, I need to plan." Eventually, she even got into arguments with managers about her schedule. She explained to me her desire to put limits on how many shifts she worked.

You're not gonna just continuously keep asking for more and more days because over time then it'll just turn into, well, instead of working two days, you'll work three days, then instead of working three days, you'll work four days. And it's like, no, I'm not doing that to myself again. Maybe that's why

they're having a hard time getting people, because it's like people realize like, I'm not gonna give myself to this restaurant. I'm not putting all my effort into it.

Natalie was eventually able to stick to working weekend brunch only; she texted me a few months after our interview and said, "only working the brunch now so I've had much more time for my other stuff and most importantly [my daughter] [heart emoji]." Natalie's struggle for control over her time reflected the gendered, moral lens through which mothers working in restaurants interpreted their work schedules. It also highlights how morality was used as a resource in resisting employer control over workers' schedules, as one of the means through which workers expressed power over their time in a tight labor market.

In turn, managers consistently articulated a sense that the moral order of their industry was being violated by workers' attempts to control their schedules. Managers' deployment of morality in this case served to stake a claim to the moral upper hand amidst shifting workplace power relations. Eusebio, a Latino man in his 40s, was an executive chef within a popular local restaurant group, and he felt that workers "broke the rules" more since the pandemic. Work hours and days off were a key site of "rule-breaking" in Eusebio's comments.

Like if somebody [is] like, "I don't want to work for three days," and [they] don't come back, and they don't show up to work the next three days, [and then] they start working [again], you not allowed to say anything. "Oh, you know what, I can work only one day and a few hours and leave and come back the next day," like, nothing.

"I don't have anybody," Eusebio added. "A lot of people took advantage of that. Are still taking advantage of it." The immoral character of these workers' actions in Eusebio's view is further highlighted by the notion that they are "taking advantage" of managers' desperation for staff.

Managers were especially critical of younger workers' approach towards work time, describing them as less work-oriented yet more entitled than older generations of restaurant workers—like their own. Peter, an upper-level manager mentioned earlier, worked for the company that owned El Amigo, and he reflected this viewpoint. He characterized himself as "a hard worker" who rose through the New York City restaurant scene, where businesses would often be open until 4 AM. "I often worked three, 15-hour days in a row and had four days off in a week." In contrast, he said, "the generation that is showing up now in the workplace, they bring a different set of values. I think some of the work-life balance issues nowadays are they need more

work in their life.” For managers like Peter, the new generation of restaurant workers’ scheduling preferences were troublesome not only because of the challenge they posed to the labor process; workers’ pursuit of more balanced work schedules challenged the belief system that legitimated the hard-driving work style through which managers had built their careers.

Some managers’ own views caused some friction or dissonance within themselves. Several managers of a more progressive bent were self-conscious about their words, reflecting to me that they sounded like out-of-touch “boomers.” As people who had slogged through the ranks of the industry, and the late hours, low pay, and managerial abuse that have characterized it, they expressed sympathy with workers standing up for themselves, in general. Peter himself said, “I’m an employee in the end also.” However, despite their favorable views about workers in general, they tended to be critical of the ways that workers exercised control over their time in practice, given the challenge to managerial ends and beliefs that such practices posed.

In sum, moral approaches to time interacted with the power afforded to workers by a tight labor market. Some workers clung to moral frameworks for work time which helped them find meaning in the “flexible” temporal demands of their work. Others, however, bolstered by their relative power and drawing on new understandings of time, deployed moral visions of time which decentered work; moral arguments were one means of expressing power. Gender and immigrant identity played an important role in some workers’ moral approaches to time. Managers, sensitive to their relative loss of power, also evaluated workers’ scheduling practices through a moral lens, casting moral judgment on some attempts to control schedules.

The Web of Time: How the Relational Nature of Work Time Can Reinforce Employer-Driven Flexibility

Finally, the nature of time as a power- and morality-laden entity overlapped and interacted with the nature of time as a relational entity within the workplace, for example between coworkers.⁸ The relational nature of work time had both a logistical and a moral component for workers. Schedule interdependence meant that changes to one worker’s schedule often logistically affected other workers. Workers also made sense of their schedules in light of their interconnectedness with others in the workplace, and for some, moral norms of reciprocity and responsibility towards coworkers translated to a sense of collective responsibility for the schedule. However, this sense of collective responsibility could ultimately encourage workers to put the needs of the business before their own desires—despite workers’ bargaining

power. The relational nature of the schedule did not necessarily empower workers, but instead indirectly exerted control over their schedules.

The interdependence of workers' schedules meant that changes in one worker's schedule could have cascading effects on others' schedules, leading to unexpected demands on their time. Sandra, a Latina dishwasher in her 30s who worked at my field site, faced such last-minute requests: "there were times when a worker was out. Oof, they would say, 'can you come [early] at 1:00? At 2:00?' [Hubo tiempos que no había un trabajador. Uf, me decían: '¿puedes venir a la 1:00? ¿A las 2:00?']". Sandra would then have to work an extra-long shift, not getting off work until late in the night. Similarly, Natalie, a server mentioned earlier, dealt with last-minute changes to her shifts. One Saturday, she worked the brunch shift, but because a coworker was sent home early, "it got so busy at night that I had to stay."

Illustrating the overlap of different aspects of time in meaning-making and practices around scheduling, moral values such as reciprocity figured strongly in how some of these workers responded to relational last-minute demands on their time. Kaya, a white bartender in her 30s, found herself picking up the slack in the schedule, especially due to COVID cases at work. She framed her action in terms of expectations of reciprocity and a sense of responsibility to her coworkers.

There's a lot more dependency on one another to like, show up for each other [...] There is a heightened sense of feeling like you have to pick up slack, because it's not like somebody just called out because they were hungover. They're just being responsible, they can't help it. So there is more of a sense of duty to [come] to work last minute or like work an extra shift or a longer hour because you know that you'll probably be in that same position in a few weeks, where you're putting someone out through no fault of your own.

Working in these conditions was hard on Kaya. "All of that flexibility that I like within the service industry is a lot harder to achieve right now," she said; indeed, she was the one being asked to be flexible. However, Kaya felt a "sense of duty" to help cover the schedule—in other words, a moral sense of responsibility to coworkers, interwoven with the expectation of reciprocity should she have to miss work.

Feelings of collective responsibility for the schedule also made some workers disinclined to exert control over their schedules by taking time off. Vanessa, a woman in her 30s who identified as mixed race (Asian/white), worked as a line cook and sous chef during the pandemic. She felt guilty about even simply taking days off because of the effects on her coworkers.

It's just never a good feeling to take days off in a restaurant because you just get riddled with all this guilt [...] because you for sure make everyone else have a way harder day and there's never a backup.

Similarly, a line cook named Drew, a white man in his 30s, said of calling out sick, especially without finding a replacement: "it's a dick move to call in sick and just leave people hanging." For both Vanessa and Drew, the implications on one's coworkers of taking time off (planned and unplanned) was important, as underscored by the morally inflected language they used—being "riddled with guilt" and calling out being a "dick move." The interconnected nature of coworkers' schedules and the sense of responsibility that Vanessa and Drew felt towards their coworkers' workloads made them reluctant to take time off. They had internalized what is ultimately the employer problem of staffing. Instead of having workers find their own replacement, even when sick, employers could do that work, or they could staff shifts more generously so that callouts are not so detrimental. But by constraining workers' expressions of power over their work time, workers' internalized relational logics served as a fix for the structural causes of short-staffing.

The linking of schedules could also create friction between coworkers when one worker tried to control their schedule in a way that resulted in more work for others. On a personal note, I realized during my fieldwork that some coworkers frowned on the fact that I usually did not work on Saturdays. On that day of the week, we had no host, and because hosts not only seated guests but also helped clean and set new tables, this meant more work for the rest of the front of the house staff. I avoided working on Saturdays to have some work-life balance of my own; if I worked Saturdays, I had to write field notes on Sundays, which were my one true day off every week. However, little comments from coworkers clued me in to their feelings, like when Brandon, a white server in his 30s, during some small talk on a Monday, told me he was super tired from working Friday, Saturday and Sunday. I replied that I was sure it was busy. He replied that there was no host again on Saturday—adding, a little coldly, "I kind of blame you for that." Similarly, while chatting one day with Walter, a food runner mentioned earlier, he found out I wasn't working Saturdays. He inquired why not and remarked with some anxiety that "se pone bien busy" [it gets rather busy]." Walter would also tease me for not working on Saturdays, like one day when I told him and the chef that I already had plans and couldn't take the shift.

"No quiere" [she doesn't want to], Walter teased me. He added playfully that the plans I had were probably "con el novio" [with the boyfriend]—he and the chef laughed. I played along and said, "quizás" [maybe]!

While overall I had friendly and supportive relationships with Brandon and Walter, moments like these showed me that I was breaking an unspoken rule about the schedule—though ultimately, the lack of a host on Saturdays was not all my own doing. One host had quit, another had moved up to serving, and managers weren't hiring new hosts to keep down payroll costs and the number of staff eating into the collective pool of tips.

The web of time that enmeshes coworkers' schedules has moral and practical implications that are experienced relationally within the workplace, including in contexts of structural power for workers and shifts in meaning-making about time. Overall, in short-staffed conditions, workers' experiences of the schedule as a web of time did not necessarily help them achieve employee-driven flexibility. Instead, a strong sense of responsibility for covering the schedule and reciprocity towards coworkers could lead to overwork and discourage workers from trying to enact control over their own time. Frictions could arise when individuals broke this code.

Discussion

"Flexibility" has coalesced as a dominant mode of organizing time in certain jobs, and it has long been the case in restaurant work. However, the pandemic offered an opportunity to explore how this time discipline fared in a period of economic and social disruption. I delved into workers' and managers' experiences with work time and flexible scheduling. I used a novel framework of three lenses on time—as a site of power, a moral entity, and a relational entity within the workplace—which, while distinct, interact and overlap with each other.

In the context of a competitive labor market and social change around the meaning of time, employer-driven flexible scheduling in restaurant work was challenged in some ways but upheld in others. This was due to the interaction of shifts in power and control over work time with the moral and relational nature of time. First, looking at time through the lens of power casts into relief the change in power dynamics between workers and managers in the pandemic workplace. The economics of the pandemic restaurant labor market afforded marketplace bargaining power to many workers, allowing them to exert more control over their schedules. Second, this context allowed some workers to also mobilize moral framings of work time which pushed back on employer-driven flexibility. Moral claims were one means through which workers made claims on their schedules and exercised their power. Others, though, held onto moral frames which reinforced employer

control over scheduling. Third, the relationally intertwined nature of scheduling also tended to support employer control over scheduled hours, due not only to workplace logistics but also to the activation of values like reciprocity and collective responsibility among workers.

My findings illustrate that meaning-making and social action in work settings, including precarious work settings, involve workers' interactions with varied aspects of time. Workers' scheduling outcomes reflect the embeddedness of work time within power, morality, and relationships. This multifaceted embeddedness can give rise to seemingly contradictory patterns—on one hand, scheduling outcomes that reproduce dominant paradigms about work time, and on the other, outcomes that challenge such paradigms.

My approach poses some limitations to keep in mind. First, my data were collected after the onset of the COVID pandemic, so comparisons between conditions pre- and post-pandemic often rely on participants' recollection. Participants' accounts of pre-pandemic work were largely consistent with existing literature about restaurant work; still, it is important to recognize that the recollection of past actions or events is subject to bias and error (Small & Cook, 2021). Second, in my fieldwork, being new to restaurant work presented both advantages and challenges; while being a novice in a field setting allows researchers to learn formal and informal norms through experience, including mistakes (Becker, 1993), I could not draw on personal previous experience in the industry in order to make comparisons between the present and pre-pandemic conditions. Third, I had the greatest personal familiarity with scheduling on the front of the house team. My data regarding scheduling in the back of the house is less in-depth; however, my fieldnotes still contained many examples of interactions and conversations regarding scheduling in the back of the house, and interviews with several back of the house coworkers triangulated my observations. Fourth, qualitative studies trade breadth for depth and thus almost never produce representative samples of the populations they study. My dataset is thus not a representative sample of restaurant workers, though it does contain a great deal of variation in both worker demographics and types of restaurants.

Additionally, the relatively pro-worker context of Philadelphia should be taken into account. The city of Philadelphia has a number of pro-worker statutes; pertinent to the present study, one of these is a Fair Workweek ordinance, effective since 2020, which aims to shield workers from unpredictable scheduling. Given that the law mainly applies to large franchises and chains, most of the participants in this study were not protected under this law. However, it is possible that the local policy environment contributes to workplace cultures that are more supportive of workers than in places lacking this environment.

Conclusion

This paper has argued that workers' temporal meaning-making and scheduling practices are embedded in multiple, intersecting aspects of time. In doing so, it builds on literatures about work time's relationship to power, morality, and relationality as well as literature about stability and change in the temporality of work.

My findings underscore that the struggle for control over time is an important feature of low-wage, flexibly-organized jobs like restaurant work, and they shed light on the relationship between structural conditions such as the labor market and mechanisms of labor control through scheduling. My research illustrates how the structural conditions of the labor market and the subsequent relative power of workers (Silver, 2006; Wright, 2000) can tilt managers' scheduling practices towards garnering the consent of workers. Managers dialed back their demands for flexibility from workers and instead often offered it to them, which could generate worker consent. The need to flexibly maintain the labor process, however, could lead managers to make demands on workers' time—which could succeed in compelling workers' labor but could also generate resistance. These findings add to other research illustrating alternation between despotic coercion and the generation of consent as labor control strategies in precarious work (Halpin, 2015; Vallas et al., 2022; Wood, 2020).

My findings also show how moral lenses interplay with workers' structural power in flexible, low-wage work. A tight labor market as well as shifts in the meaning of time due to the social disruption of the pandemic conditioned alternative moral lenses towards work time that decentered work. These lenses were resources through which workers could stake claims and express power in the workplace. Building on studies of moral approaches to work time (Snyder, 2016), these findings show how the structural context of moral lenses shape their power. Additionally, my findings about the interplay of worker identity with workers' moral approaches to time contribute to literature about social structure, identity, and morality in the low-wage workplace (Dodson, 2007; Gomberg-Muñoz, 2010; Lamont, 2000).

Like Wood (2020), I argue that the relational nature of time within the workplace matters for meaning-making in precarious work settings, though I focus on coworker relationships rather than employer–employee relationships. I also argue that the activation of values like reciprocity and solidarity due to interrelated schedules can result in tension with workers' own scheduling desires. This notion conflicts with previous research arguing that the interdependence of schedules promotes solidarity as well as employee-powered flexibility (Clawson & Gerstel, 2014). Values like reciprocity and

solidarity are usually viewed as boons for workers that can promote a sense of dignity (Hodson, 2001) and lead to associational power (Wright, 2000). Indeed, as I vividly observed in my fieldwork as well as interviews, relationships with coworkers (as well as managers) deeply shape restaurant workers' experiences, and camaraderie has real benefits. However, when solidarity results in workers taking on the burden of solving the staffing problems of a business, it does not necessarily afford power or control to workers. While Clawson and Gerstel (2014) found that solving scheduling issues through employee swaps fostered solidarity among workers, I observed that scheduling norms among coworkers acted as a lateral mechanism of control over the labor process (Burawoy, 2010), potentially dispersing conflict between employers and workers into conflict between peers. Meanwhile, employers were relieved of some of the blame for scheduling dilemmas and staffing problems. These findings link the study of precarious work schedules to scholarship positing relational work as a mechanism of labor control (Mears, 2015), as well as the role of relationships as a labor control and source of meaning in restaurant work (Fine, 1996; Gomberg-Muñoz, 2019; Hill, 2018; Kim, 2009, 2012).

Zooming out, my findings have implications for understanding how meanings and practices around time can change—as well as how they resist change—in flexible work from the ground up. Previous research suggests that economic disruption—in this case, tight labor markets (LaBriola & Schneider, 2020; Newman & Jacobs, 2023)—can improve working conditions. Meanwhile, transformations in meaning-making around time during the pandemic (Ravenelle & Kowalski, 2022) also suggested the possibility of change for workers. However, I found both change and continuity to the paradigm of employer-driven flexibility. The multidimensional nature of time within the context of the workplace helps explain this variation. Elements of work time like the moral and the relational interacted with changes in power and control over work time, so that in some situations, workers' schedules were more employee-driven, while in other situations they were structured along the lines of employer demand.

Taking account of these various factors highlights the challenges of totally upending taken-for-granted practices and meanings associated with flexibility in restaurants; such an upending would challenge the logistics of the labor process, deep-seated moral frameworks regarding work, and workers' relationships with their colleagues and bosses. Swidler notes that whether a new set of cultural ideas and values takes hold in a given setting during “unsettled periods” depends on context, including structure and competing cultural frameworks: “it is [...] the concrete situations in which [new] cultural models are enacted that determine which take root and thrive, and which

with and die” (1986, p. 280). Similarly, meanings and practices around scheduling amidst the “unsettled times” of pandemic restaurant work were negotiated in the context of existing organizational structure and culture that are not easily dislodged, even in a tight labor market.

One potential avenue to extend this research lies in looking more closely at managers’ meaning-making around their own work time. Given that restaurant managers supplement the labor of their staff when needed, for example by cooking or waiting on tables, managers’ schedules are subject to some of the same demands for flexibility as their staff. Managers in my study often worked upwards of sixty hours per week and experienced routine unpredictability in their schedules. Considering managers’ experiences of their own work time in this setting, including the various aspects of time that compose their sense-making, may shed further light on the organizational production of flexible scheduling. In fact, a study of scheduling practices in retail suggests that constraints on managers’ own time make it harder for them to provide schedules to workers with significant advance notice (Lambert, Henly, Schoeny et al., 2019).

Another direction for future research is to examine meanings and practices around scheduling over a longer period of time. One may ask whether the patterns I observed persisted when the labor market changed, or whether conditions in restaurants and similar workplaces then also changed. Some of my data points to a decrease in worker power as 2020 recedes further into memory. Furthermore, quantitative research suggests that as workers’ structural power decreases, the degree of schedule unpredictability they face increases, especially in low-wage work (LaBriola & Schneider, 2020). Additionally, it is possible that the moral frames some workers used to resist employer-driven flexibility hold less sway when workers have less bargaining power. It is feasible that, in the absence of other forms of power like associational power (Wright, 2000) or protective legislation, workers’ greater control over scheduling and the ground to stake moral claims that decenter work will erode.

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Notes

1. In this paper, precarious work refers to “work that is *uncertain, unstable, and insecure* and in which *employees bear the risks* of work (as opposed to businesses or the government) and *receive limited social benefits and statutory protections*” (Kalleberg & Vallas, 2017, p. 1).
2. While employing this framework, I take for granted that the meaning of work time is first a practical means to income; however, these other dimensions interact with the pragmatic relationship between work time and pay.
3. Additionally, employers sometimes purposefully overschedule workers, anticipating they will cut as they need to during a shift, as well as conceal information about shift start and end times (Halpin, 2015). Employers sometimes also ask workers to work off the clock (Wilson, 2020).
4. I am proficient in Spanish and conducted a small number of interviews in Spanish, but I preferred for these to be conducted by fluent or native Spanish speakers in order to best accommodate participants.
5. At my field site, front of the house and back of the house scheduling were conducted separately, by different managers. Both schedules were generally released weekly. The front of the house schedule was published on a scheduling app, and following a change in management, a paper copy was also posted in the main server area. In contrast, the back of the house schedule was posted on paper in the kitchen, usually on Sundays.

6. As happens during tight labor markets (Paules, 1991), managers were on the hook to act as fill-in labor when there was an unfilled hole in the schedule—serving tables themselves, hosting, cooking, busing tables, and washing dishes. This cut into managers' other tasks, like supervision and payroll, could lead to overwork, and conflicted with managers' sense of being "above" such work. This speaks to the relational and moral nature of work time for workers and managers, themes I will expand on later.
7. However, immigrant men with children in the U.S. conceptualized their time in ways that were relatively similar to how mothers (who I discuss later) did; fathers with children in the U.S. also felt the moral pull of caregiving as an influence on their time, though it was not necessarily as strong as among mothers.
8. I also observed the relational nature of time between workers and managers, and the practical and moral interconnectedness of worker and manager schedules; however, here I limit my scope to the relational nature of time between coworkers.

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